

XR Open Call – 08 | 2025

"Jewish Life in Islamic and Arab Countries"

Makor Foundation for Israeli Films

Makor Media: Storytelling and New Technologies Lab

In collaboration with:

Israel Lottery Council for Culture and the Arts - Mifal HaPais

The French Institute in Israel – The French Embassy in Israel

Kan – Israeli Public Broadcasting Corporation

NewImages Festival

Anu - Museum of the Jewish People

Alma Films

**Independent creators, in collaboration with technology artists,
are invited to submit proposals for immersive storytelling projects
focusing on Jewish Life in Islamic and Arab Countries.**

Background:

The history of Jewish communities in the lands of Islam constitutes a rich and significant chapter in the story of the Jewish people. Viewed through the lens of the centuries that followed the rise of Islam in the 7th century up to the beginning of the 20th century, what emerges is a vivid portrait of thriving Jewish communities across North Africa, the Middle East, the Ottoman Empire and Asia. As Islam spread rapidly across the region and beyond, the Jewish world began to respond, laying the foundations for the evolving relationship between Jews and Muslims.

Only in recent years has this chapter of Jewish history - centered in the lands of Islam - begun to receive broader recognition. Stories, communities, key figures and lived experiences that were long marginalized, forgotten, or insufficiently acknowledged, are gradually being integrated into the larger historical and cultural narrative. Connecting with this past through new media opens up new possibilities for telling the stories of these communities in ways that are resonant, immersive, and relevant today.

This open call refers to *new media* as narrative and immersive works that fall under the umbrella of XR – Extended Reality. Proposed works may take one of the following forms:

Augmented Reality (AR) –using mediation tools such as a phone, tablet, or headset to overlay experiences onto physical spaces or specific physical elements;
 Virtual Reality (VR) – using a headset to present either passive 360° video or interactive 360° experiences that fully surround the user;
 and Mixed Reality (MR) – combining AR and VR, enabling both interaction and spatial awareness by overlaying virtual content onto the physical environment through a headset.

Additionally, proposals may include immersive video installations designed for exhibition spaces in which the experience is projected onto all walls and viewed without mediation devices.

The visual language and expressive tools may include 360° live-action or documentary video, animation, graphics and design, or a combination of visual, sonic, and haptic elements. Use of AI-based tools is also welcome.

Immersive and interactive experiences offer new ways to represent and recreate the past. They allow us to deconstruct and reassemble the lives – social, religious, and cultural experiences of individuals and communities – as well as the experience of immigration and displacement. Immersive environments allow narratives to “breathe” and invite the viewer to become an active participant in an emotional, cultural, and historical journey. These experiences help shape compelling and resonant narratives, fostering deeper identification, empathy, and historical insight.

For the first time within the framework of Makor Foundation's open calls for new media projects, this initiative includes a collaboration with an independent production company - Alma Films that is concurrently producing a 10-episode documentary series on the subject matter for the Israeli Public Broadcasting Corporation – Kan 11. They are investors in the XR experiences and partners, but not producers. This collaboration is in addition to our partnerships with the Israel Lottery Council for Culture and the Arts (Mifal HaPais), the French Institute in Israel and NewImages Festival in Paris. Additionally, the completed immersive works are expected to be showcased at ANU - Museum of the Jewish People, timed to coincide with the broadcast of the

documentary series on Kan 11.

Open Call Objectives:

This open call aims to support the development and production of new media works that tell the stories of Jewish communities in the Islamic countries, with an emphasis on narratives that demonstrate a clear storytelling arc and a distinctive, innovative artistic language. Creators are expected to select a story, character(s), event and historical period that reflect the uniqueness and identity of a specific community, culture, time and place. The thematic scope spans nearly 1,500 years and encompasses a wide geographical range, offering numerous directions for exploration and focus.

Unlike the goals of the documentary series being produced in parallel - which aims to provide a broad and comprehensive historical overview - **applicants to this open call are expected to create intimate, immersive experiences, amplified by the technologies and expressive languages unique to new media narratives. Submitted projects must focus on characters, events, or communities that existed between the early 7th century (around the rise of Islam) and the year 1900.**

In addition, the creators, who will receive production grants from the foundation and partners, will also be asked to prepare a short film of approximately 8-12 minutes in length that will be based on the proposed content. The film is intended to be uploaded on Kan's platforms to promote the documentary series and immersive experiences. At the submission stage, there is no need to provide details about the content of the video, but to focus solely on the immersive experience. The content of the video will be determined at a later date between the creators and the project funding partners.

For inspiration and to better understand the historical context and spirit of the time and place, applicants may refer to the summary of the documentary series included below (without section Four, which is about the 20th century). This overview is intended for background purposes only and does not require any narrative or conceptual overlap between the series and the proposed immersive projects.

Open Call Process and Timeline:

In the first stage, 6-8 projects will be selected from all eligible applications. Each proposal must be submitted by a team consisting of a creator (writer/director) and a creative technologist (see eligibility details below). The selected projects will participate in a professional incubator workshop in Tel Aviv in November 2025 (full schedule follows). **The selected teams are required to participate and be physically present throughout the entire workshop.**

The purpose of the workshop is to provide guidance, support and mentorship from leading professionals in the fields of screenwriting, new media, animation and technology. In addition, teams will receive support in developing an impact strategy for production and distribution. The goal is to refine and improve the projects in all aspects, including narrative, content, script, visual language, creative expression, production and marketing/distribution plans, and to ensure that each project aligns with a realistic budget.

As part of the workshop activities in November, an Open Industry Day will be held in which all selected teams are required to attend.

At the conclusion of the Workshop, and following the submission of final proposals, 3 projects will be selected to receive funding from Makor Foundation, with the support of Mifal HaPais-Israel State Lottery and other partners. Each selected project will receive an investment of approximately 433,000 NIS for production.

To streamline production costs and meet the exhibition timeline, the three selected projects will be produced in collaboration with an independent production company experienced in XR productions, to be appointed at a later stage. The terms of engagement between the creators and the production company will be defined following the selection of the projects.

The three selected teams will also participate in the XR co-production market at the NewImages Festival in Paris, in Spring 2026. This visit is intended to expose the projects to international producers, distributors, creators, institutions and potential partners. Participation in the festival is mandatory and requires the presence and full participation of both members of the creative team. The creators of the selected projects will receive partial funding to cover participation expenses at the festival. If

they wish, they may use their production grant to cover any remaining costs.

The 3 selected projects, including the 2D short film versions (8-12 mins.), must be finalized and ready for public presentation by July 2027, in coordination with the anticipated broadcast of the documentary series on Kan 11 and the parallel public showcase of the immersive experiences at Anu – Museum of the Jewish People.

Eligibility Criteria:

Residents and citizens of the State of Israel are entitled to submit. Proposals may be submitted by creators who are not residents, or Israeli citizens but they must apply through a resident producer / creator who is an Israeli citizen.

The production of a project submitted by a non-Israeli creator will be require that at least 75% of all creators above the line (producer, director, screenwriter, editor) are Israeli citizens.

All submissions will be made using an online form in Hebrew on Makor's website (more details below), yet applicants must have a good understanding of spoken and written English.

Each proposal must include at least:

1. one creator (director/ screenwriter/ animator)
2. one technology artist.

If the creator is not an Israeli citizen or resident, the proposal must be submitted through a producer who is an Israeli citizen.

Open Call Schedule:

An Open Industry Day	3.4.2025
Open call launch	3.8.2025
Open call deadline	14.9.2025 at 16:00
First evaluation phase	16.9.2025 – 16.10.2025
Second evaluation phase	19-26.10.2025
Final selection committee meeting	27.10.2025
Notification to applicants of results	28.10.2025
(e-mail notifications are sent to 6-8 teams selected & and to all other applicants)	

Professional incubator workshop (for selected teams)	17-20.11.2025
Open Industry Day (open to the public)	19.11.2025
Submission of final projects	18.12.2025
Final selection of 3 granted projects	8.1.2026

Submission Form:

Requirements for submitting the application, in Hebrew only, on [Makor's website](https://www.kerenmakor.org.il):

- **Personal information of the applicant and other creators** – director and technology artist + a link to previous works. Also, details regarding the screenwriter/ animator/ producer (if applicable).
- **Logline** of up to 30 words.
- **Runtime** of the work.
- **Development or production funding partners** - Not obligatory at this time. If applicable, please indicate the name of the funding body and the amount.
- **Budget** - Not obligatory at this time. You can upload a PDF file only with **no identifying details**. The budget items will relate to the team's various roles - script, storyboard, design, animation/ photography, technology, editing, on-line editing and sound. You may refer to the sample budget file [available for download on Makor's website](https://www.kerenmakor.org.il).
- **Synopsis** – **mandatory**. Up to 500 words. character description and the narrative course of the experience.
- **Statement of Intent** – **mandatory**. Up to 500 words: What is the reason and motivation for creating the experience. What is the idea for dealing with the issue behind the story. What is the intended technology and how does it serve the story.
- **Treatment and characters** – optional at this time. Up to 1,000 words. A list of scenes with a brief description of the events in each scene, including detailed characterization of the involved characters.
- **Visual language** – **mandatory**. up to 500 words. the components of the visual language, detailing the overall audio-visual experience with references to the visual style, the intended environment/ location, the characters and their backgrounds. **No links should be included in this field (A separate field for attaching visuals is provided later).**
- **Screenplay**: 4-8 pages. Not obligatory at this time, in accordance with specifications

that appear in a sample script form [available for download from Makor's website](#).

You can upload a PDF file only with **no identifying details**

- **Images:** recommended. visual materials that support the artist's artistic-stylistic vision, characters, backgrounds, storyboard, mood-board, references - up to 8 JPEG/PNG files (Max 60MB).
- **Video materials:** recommended, not obligatory at this time. A trailer or rough sample of the video, **without any identifying details**. Please include a link (and password, if applicable). The materials must remain available for viewing for at least three months and must not be altered in any way. If the applicant wishes to update the submitted video materials after submission, this may only be done with prior written approval from the Foundation. If it is found that the materials were modified without such approval, the submission will be disqualified.

Overview of the 10-parts documentary series, without section Four, which is about the 20th century (for inspiration only)

Section One – The Rise of Muhammad and the Jewish Golden Age

After the destruction of the Second Temple, Jewish communities were dispersed, distinct and separate. Muhammad's birth and the rise of Islam swept the region. Jewish communities' varied responses shaped Jewish-Arab relations and led to the Jewish Golden Age in Spain. This period leads to the Golden Age in Spain, the development and consolidation of the Jewish language and literary canon, and ultimately to the expulsion from Spain.

Period: From the rise of Islam (~700 CE) through the Middle Ages to the expulsion from Spain (1492) and Safed (15th century). *Regions:* Arabian Peninsula, Babylonia, Spain, North Africa.

Section Two – The Aftershocks of the Expulsion from Spain

The expulsion flooded the Ottoman Arab world with Jewish refugees from Spain and Portugal. Cultural, religious, and economic differences between the Sephardic refugees and the established Musta'arabi¹ communities led to leadership struggles and tensions between rivalry and integration efforts. Ottoman religious autonomy redefined relations with Muslims and inspired messianic creativity. Waves of prosperity and hardship affected material culture and caused disputes over identity and Jewish law amid existential survival struggles. The printing press and scientific revolution challenged traditional ways of life.

Period: 15th–18th century. *Regions:* Ottoman Empire, North Africa, Persia, Yemen, Bukhara.

Section Three – Colonialism and Nationalism: Welcome to Modernity

New communication and travel routes connected Jewish communities globally, creating a transnational Jewish consciousness with internal hierarchies. The Ottoman Empire's collapse and colonialism introduced new identities and tensions between Jews of Islam and European Jews. The establishment of Israel and the disappearance of Jewish presence in Muslim lands erased many of these possibilities.

Period: 18th century–1948. *Regions:* Ottoman Empire, North Africa, Iraq, Yemen.

¹ (Arabic: المستعربين al-Musta'ribīn "Mozarabs") were the Arabic-speaking Jews, largely Mizrahi Jews and Maghrebi Jews, who lived in the Middle East and North Africa.